it is necessary to situate them and the group within a wider context over the last twenty years.

In this book I argue that Lashkar's evolution is informed by two defining dualities: the first is its identity as a militant outfit *and* as a missionary organization committed to promoting its interpretation of Ahl-e-Hadith Islam; the second concerns its military activities, namely that it is both a proxy used to further Pakistan's national interests against India *and* a pan-Islamist group dedicated to waging jihad against all enemies of Islam. As *Storming the World Stage* will demonstrate, Lashkar managed to evolve into a powerful and protected organization in Pakistan as a result of its ability to reconcile these dualities. A jihad against India to liberate Muslim land deemed to be under Hindu occupation aligned with Lashkar's ideological priorities and also with state interests. This enabled the group to become Pakistan's most reliable proxy, which brought with it substantial benefits including the support needed to construct a robust social welfare apparatus used for missionary and reformist purposes. Reconciling these dualities also necessitated deals and compromises, since preserving its position vis-à-vis the state sometimes forced the group to sublimate its pan-Islamist impulses. The need for such trade-offs became more acute after 9/11, and as the decade wore on pressure to expand its participation in the global jihad against America and its allies increased. Mumbai had multiple objectives, one of which was to generate momentum for the group at a time when it was in danger of being eclipsed by other outfits deemed more committed to that cause.

To appreciate Lashkar's dual identity as a missionary and militant organization, we must go back to 1982, when Zaki-ur Rehman Lakhvi, then a student from Punjab in Pakistan and now accused of masterminding the 2008 Mumbai attacks, went to Paktia in Afghanistan to wage jihad against the Soviets.[3] A member of the Ahl-e-Hadith sect of Islam, he initially fought alongside members of the Deobandi school of thought whom he believed were not waging jihad according to sharia [Islamic law]. The Ahl-e-Hadith are Salafist in orientation, meaning they believe Muslims must return to a pure form of Islam and advocate emulating the Prophet and his Companions in all areas of life.[4] In 1984, Lakhvi broke away and formed a small Ahl-e-Hadith group of his own. A year later, Hafiz Mohammad Saeed and Zafar Iqbal, two teachers at the University of Engineering and Technology (Lahore) Pakistan, formed Jamaat-ul-Dawa [Organization for